

How to Select the Right Desktop Scanners

It's a challenge to find the right scanner. You cannot just decide on any scanner as these vary in shape, size and also the purpose they serve. Here is a guide to make sure you pick the right scanner to suit your requirements.

Desktop scanners are specialised devices designed to make speedy work of removing piles of paper from the desk and transferring all that content onto the desktop or computer. This is the product that does the job of managing files and documents quickly and accurately. Gone are the days when only Internet cafes had scanners. If you still keep a bundle or albums of photographs, or a file full of hard copies of important documents, a desktop scanner can make your life easy and manageable. A scanner can not only bring your memories back to life whenever you want to view your photograph collection, but it also ensures both pictures and documents are safely stored and easy to manage. "Today, there are a lot of documents at home, like loan documents, insurance policies, personal certificates, old school photographs which are printed, as earlier there were no digital photographs...and we would like to keep all these documents secure with us. So we have introduced a product keeping all these things in mind, which can be carried anywhere and weighs just 550 grams; you can connect it to a laptop without using any external power (USB)," explains Jaspreet Kohli, senior manager, sales and marketing, IMS, Canon India Pvt Ltd. Desktop scanners are also great at managing heavy or bulky documents like magazines or books. Most scanners these days connect to the computer or PC through USB cables, but some are even operated wirelessly.

The demand for scanners is increasing rapidly. Today's scanners are highly specialised, and they vary in shape, size, price and even the purpose they serve. The market offers scanners of different specifications, to address varied requirements. According to Kohli, "We go to different kinds of customers, try to understand their requirements and then try to bring in that technology or the product required for the Indian market. Our USP is not just the technology but our service. We cater to more than 3000 cities in India. Today, what customers look at is also the after sales service, and Canon definitely offers good service to the customers. We also give end-to-end solutions."

Factors to be considered while buying a desktop scanner

Portability

Portability is one of the most important factors a buyer should consider while buying a scanner. From the

innumerable scanners in the market, you must first look for the brands that offer portable scanners instead of the heavy, bulky ones, and then compare other aspects. The target audience of portable scanners comprises the home segments, SOHO, or professionals like lawyers who cannot carry huge files everyday. Having said that, many portable models are fairly basic, which end up scanning only one side of the paper at one time. So, for office use, you may not want a portable scanner.

Resolution

You would not want a document or a photograph scanned with a low resolution. So another factor to keep in mind while selecting a scanner is the resolution it offers. But you will have to be very careful about keeping your documents clean, as most high resolution devices will magnify dust or scratches on the document even more clearly.

Flatbed or sheet feeder?

Select a flatbed scanner in case you don't require to scan three dimensional objects or documents longer than one or two pages. Opening the flatbed and adjusting the sheet once or twice a day will not be a problem, but having to repeat this process 10 times a day can be tedious and that is when you need a sheet feeder. So choose between a flatbed scanner and a sheet feeder keeping your requirements in mind.

Duplex

A duplex scanner is one that scans both the sides of the document at the same time. These models have dual scan elements, enabling them to scan on both the sides simultaneously. If you do not require this feature too often, then a manual duplexing in the driver is the most economical choice.

Software

Almost all the scanners available in the market work with just about any scanning related software, but if particular software that you need already comes with the scanner, you would not have to pay extra for it. Some of the software these days offer features like photo editing, text indexing, optical character recognition (OCR), a business card program or the ability to create PDF documents.